

Jayson Tatum's Return Opened the Celtics' Next Chapter

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Executive Summary

Less than a year after rupturing his Achilles, Jayson Tatum returned to a Celtics team that had already been better than expected without him.

He was not immediately the same scorer he had been prior to the injury, but the rest of his game still looked familiar. He defended across matchups, rebounded at a high level, kept the offense organized, and gave Boston the steady decision-making it had been missing from its best player.

That is the version of Tatum the Celtics built a champion around in 2024. He was a player who could shift with a series, handle different coverages, and impact games even when the jumper was not carrying him.

Before the injury, Tatum was already a four-time First Team All-NBA player and one of the league's defining stars. The Achilles rupture put that level in question. His return did not erase every concern, but by the playoffs, the outlook looked a lot better. Even while sharing more of the scoring load with Jaylen Brown, Tatum looked closer to the player Boston had trusted for years.

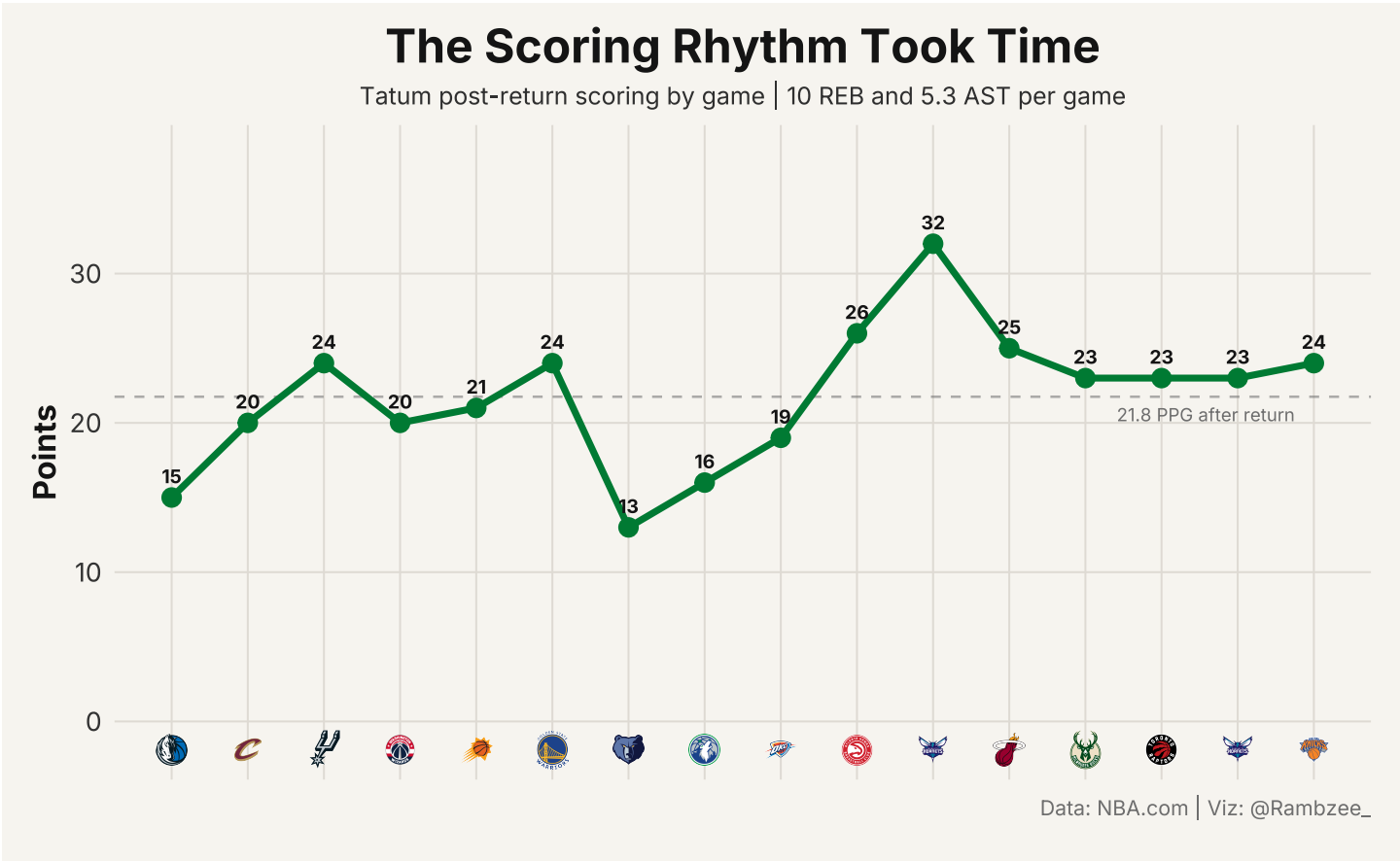
The Scoring Fluctuated

Table 1: Tatum's regular-season profile before and after the Achilles return

Metric	2024-25	2025-26	Change
GP	72.0	16.0	—
PTS	26.8	21.8	-5.0
REB	8.7	10.0	+1.3
AST	6.0	5.3	-0.7
STL	1.1	1.4	+0.3
TOV	2.9	2.4	-0.5
FGA	20.3	17.9	-2.4
FG%	45.2%	41.1%	-4.1%
3P%	34.3%	32.9%	-1.4%
2P%	55.9%	49.3%	-6.6%
TS%	58.2%	54.1%	-4.1%

The scoring decline was less about Tatum disappearing and more about the details that usually separate his offense. He was still getting shots up and drawing attention, but the burst, balance, and comfort playing through contact were not fully back yet. The clearest sign was inside the arc, where his two-point percentage dropped from 55.9% to 49.3%.

The Ramp-Up



Tatum took some time to find his footing as a scorer, but the late-season direction was promising. After some uneven nights early in the return, he settled into the mid-20s by the end of the regular season.

The Impact Translated Before the Scoring Fully Did

Table 2: Boston’s regular-season lineup performance with and without Jayson Tatum

Group	MIN	OFF	DEF	NET
Tatum ON	522	123.2	111.8	+11.4
Tatum OFF	3424	120.7	113.4	+7.3
ON - OFF	—	2.5	-1.6	+4.1

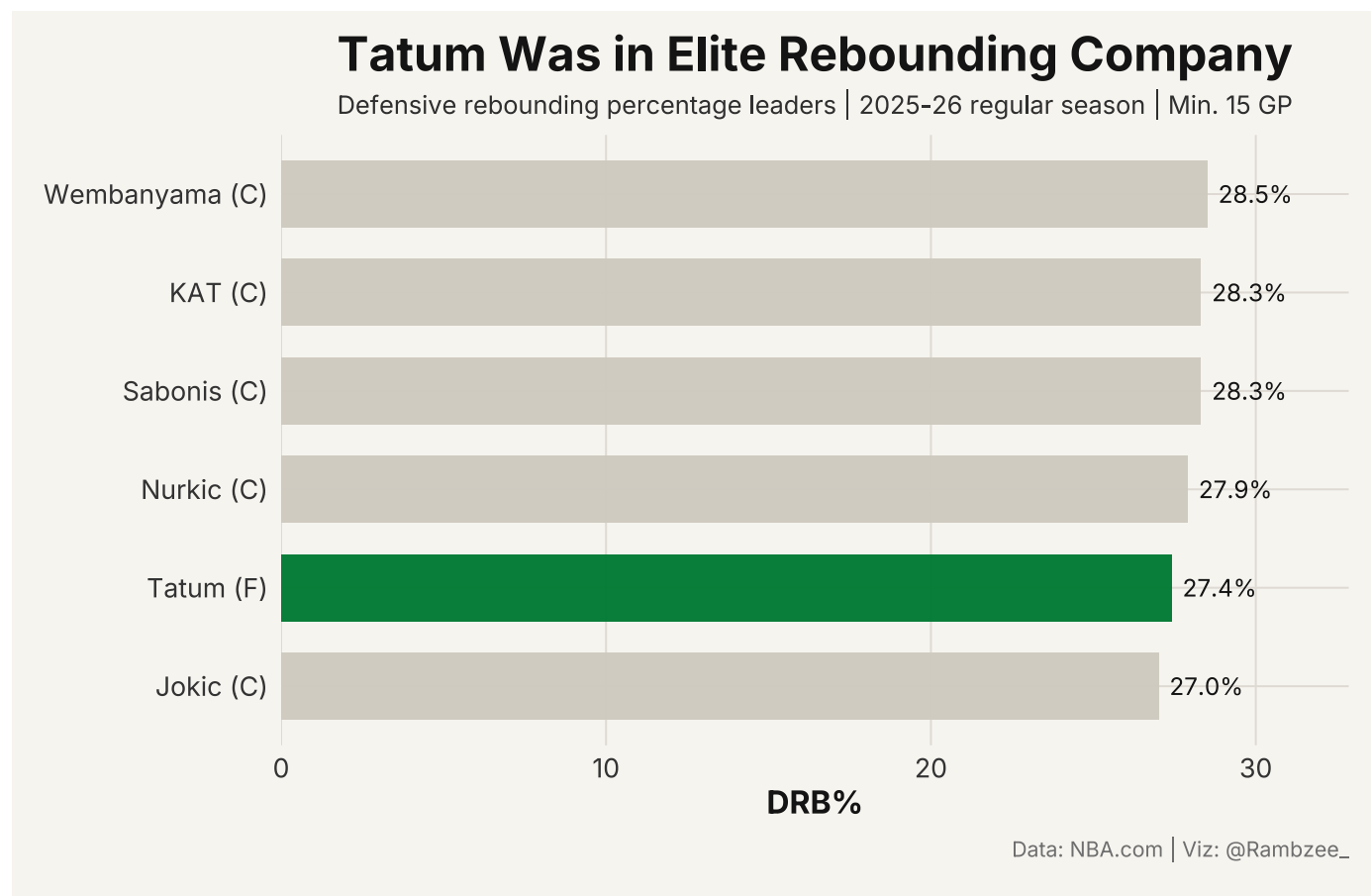
Despite the shaky scoring, Tatum’s impact came back quickly. In his 522 regular-season minutes, Boston posted a +11.4 net rating, compared with +7.3 when he sat.

That split is not a perfect measure of individual value, especially across 16 games. Lineups, opponents, and shooting swings all have to be taken into consideration. Still, it matched the larger takeaway that Boston had another level with Tatum back on the floor. His rebounding, decision-making, and control of the game led to immediate impact for the Celtics.

The Rebounding Remained High-Level

Table 3: Most rebounds per game from Tatum's March 6 return through the end of the regular season | Min. 15 GP

Rank	Player	Team	RPG
1	Nikola Jokic	DEN	13.6
2	Victor Wembanyama	SAS	12.3
3	Karl-Anthony Towns	NYK	11.9
4	Donovan Clingan	POR	11.8
5	Rudy Gobert	MIN	11.4
6	Bam Adebayo	MIA	10.7
7	Evan Mobley	CLE	10.0
7	Jalen Duren	DET	10.0
7	Jayson Tatum	BOS	10.0



From his return through the end of the regular season, Tatum averaged 10.0 boards per game and posted a 27.4% defensive rebounding rate, right in the range of several true centers. That gave Boston lineup flexibility it had missed for most of the season, letting the Celtics play smaller and keep more skill on the floor without giving up the glass.

A Methodical Offensive Engine

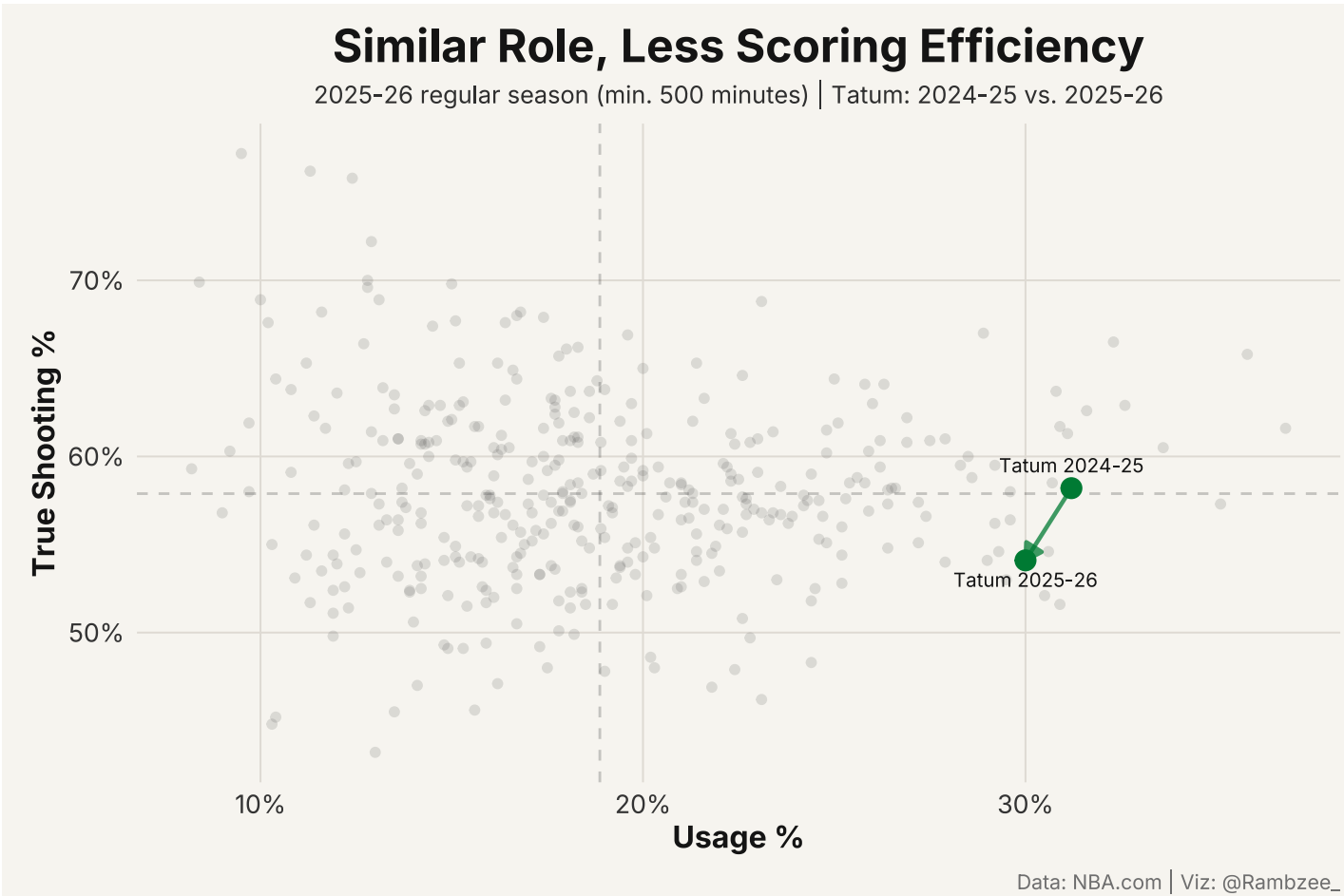
Table 4: Tatum’s playmaking indicators during the return season

Indicator	Value	Context
Touches per game	76.3	Slightly smaller role-size
Last season touches per game	84.9	Pre-injury baseline
Potential assists	15.4	91st percentile
Rim assists	3.0	89th percentile

The most reassuring development may have been how patiently Tatum controlled the offense. His touches dipped slightly from the year before, but the passing indicators were strong: 15.4 potential assists and 3.0 rim assists, both near the top of the league.

Boston kept him in a familiar role, and that part of his game translated right away. Tatum still looked comfortable reading help, controlling the pace, and finding the right pass without rushing. If anything, his playmaking looked even more polished while the scoring efficiency worked its way back.

Similar Responsibility, Lower Regular-Season Efficiency



The Scoring Caught Up in the Playoffs

Table 5: Tatum's 2026 playoff production

Metric	Value	Note
MPG	36.3	
PTS	23.3	
REB	10.7	
AST	6.8	<i>Career playoff high</i>
STL	1.2	
TOV	2.8	
FG%	47.5	<i>Career playoff high</i>
3P%	36.5%	
2P%	59.2%	<i>Career playoff high</i>
eFG%	56.9%	<i>Career playoff high</i>
TS%	60.8%	<i>Career playoff high</i>

The playoffs were the clearest sign that the regular-season efficiency dip was not Tatum's new baseline. He looked more comfortable creating off the dribble and getting downhill, finishing at 47.5% from the field, 59.2% inside the arc, and 60.8% true shooting.

The rebounding and playmaking were there from the start. Once the scoring started to catch up, his place among the playoff leaders reflected it.

Playoff Rankings

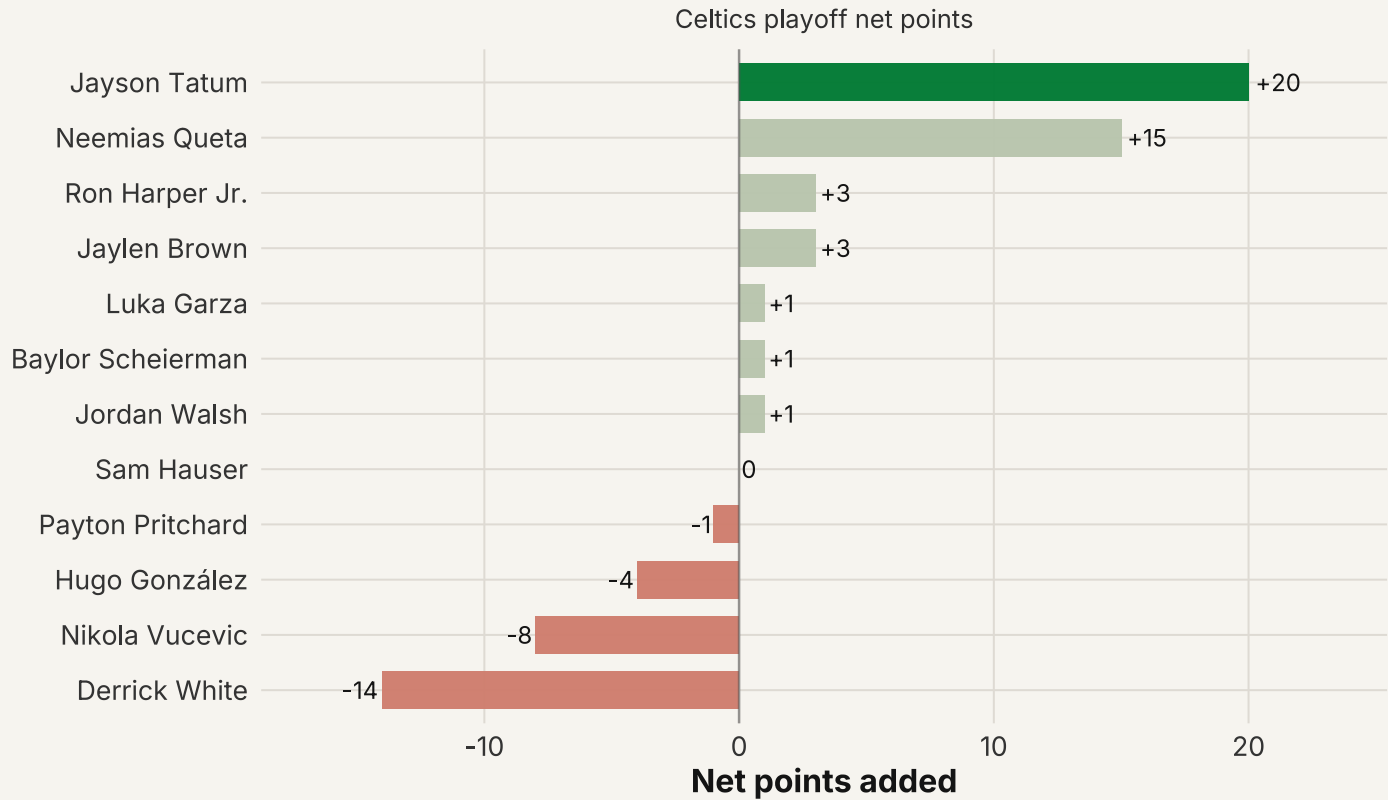
Table 6: Where Tatum ranked among 2026 playoff leaders

Category	Rank	Player	Value
Points	12	Victor Wembanyama	23.8
	13	Tyrese Maxey	23.7
	14	Jamal Murray	23.7
	15	Jayson Tatum	23.3
	16	LeBron James	23.2
Rebounds	1	Nikola Jokic	13.2
	2	Victor Wembanyama	10.9
	3	Jayson Tatum	10.7
	4	Karl-Anthony Towns	10.6
	5	Alperen Sengun	10.2
Assists	1	Nikola Jokic	9.5
	2	Scottie Barnes	8.6
	3	Shai Gilgeous-Alexander	7.9
	4	Cade Cunningham	7.5
	5	LeBron James	7.3
	6	Jrue Holiday	7.2
	7	Jayson Tatum	6.8

Boston Still Ran Through Him

Net Points Definition: Net Points is a play-by-play based metric that assigns credit and blame for every possession while a player is on the floor, capturing scoring, turnovers, defense, and context beyond the box score. It reflects how much a player moved the score rather than only what appeared in his individual line.

Tatum Gave Boston Its Biggest Playoff Lift



Data: ESPN Analytics | Viz: @Rambzee_

Table 7: Boston's playoff performance with and without Jayson Tatum | 50% offensive and defensive 3-point luck adjustments

Group	MIN	OFF	DEF	NET
Tatum ON	201	118.0	112.0	+6.0
Tatum OFF	92	104.9	111.5	-6.6
ON - OFF	—	13.1	0.5	+12.7

By the end of the playoffs, Tatum had answered much of the doubt that came with the injury. Boston's future was still going to run through him.

The Celtics struggled immensely in the minutes without him, especially on offense. He finished with Boston's best net-points mark at +20, and the adjusted on/off split showed a 13.1-point offensive gap with him on the floor.

Note: Playoff on/off ratings use Databallr's 50% offensive and defensive three-point luck adjustment, which helps reduce the effect of hot or cold shooting in a small sample. It does not remove the other noise that comes with 201 Tatum minutes and 92 non-Tatum minutes, including lineup context, matchup patterns, and rotation timing. The split should be read as directional, not definitive.

What This Means Going Forward

After the first major physical setback of his career, Tatum gave Boston real reason to believe. The scoring needed time, but the rebounding, playmaking, defense, and versatility were there almost immediately. By the playoffs, the scoring started to follow. The roster around him may change, the money may get tighter, and Boston may have to build differently, but the postseason brought the same truth back into focus: whatever comes next for the Celtics, it starts with Tatum.